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Part I

1

Introduction*

Sandra Lapointe and Clinton Tolley

§1 A unique philosophical dialogue

The present volume contains an altogether remarkable document in the history of nineteenth-century philosophy: a critical commentary on the most influential systematic work (the *Critique of Pure Reason*) of one major philosopher (Kant), written from the point of view of another major systematic philosopher (Bolzano), just decades after the former's publication. Bolzano, at the height of his powers, and with his mature philosophical views having fully taken shape with the publication of his *Theory of Science* (1837), undertakes the project of engaging, key point by key point, with Kant's masterwork. In collaboration with Bolzano, František Příhonský (who would ultimately publish the final record of this work in 1850, shortly after Bolzano's death) both compiles a comprehensive and thorough summary of the main definitions, theses, and arguments in Kant's book, and then proceeds to bring to light the most important unclarities, confusions, and fallacies that he finds each step along the way. The result, *New Anti-Kant*, is not only an extremely useful and even-handed overview of the entire first *Critique* itself – including parts often neglected by even Kant's most sympathetic readers – but also a catalogue of philosophically insightful and textually well-grounded challenges to signature Kantian doctrines. This work helps us to see anew the overarching contours of Kant's philosophy, and brings a fresh focus onto deep points of tension within Kant's system – all the while serving to introduce us, through instructive contrast, to

* Our thanks go to Edgar Morscher for his extraordinary generosity and inspiring encouragements. We owe much to his input and his detailed introduction of the new edition of the *Neuer Anti-Kant*.

the powerful alternative perspective that Bolzano develops in his own systematic philosophy.

The value of *New Anti-Kant* rests at once in the fabulous richness of Bolzano's own theories as well as in the diligence and insight with which he approached Kant's *Critique*. After a 'Preface' that motivates the need for such a project, the volume begins with an 'Introduction' that contains a concise and very helpful summary of those of Bolzano's doctrines that are most relevant to the criticisms that follow. The main part, the 'Treatise', consists of a systematic examination of the entirety of the first *Critique*. Towards the end, it also engages in an extensive discussion of the moral theory found in Kant's other writings. Throughout, the 'Treatise' alternates between extremely economical, well-articulated little digests of Kant's main doctrines following the order in which they appear in the *Critique*, followed by 'Objections' and 'Remarks' in which Příhonský deftly recapitulates the essence of Bolzano's concerns with the Kantian philosophy and thereby assesses Kant's views in light of Bolzano's own theories.

Beyond the originality and intelligence of its critical perspective, *New Anti-Kant* thus has the merit of offering an exhaustive discussion of Kant's philosophy, one which devotes its attention to both the doctrines of the *Critique* that have traditionally been of most interest to Kant scholars (e.g. the distinction between concepts and intuitions, the distinction between analytic and synthetic judgements, the possibility of synthetic *a priori* cognition, the nature of space and time, the transcendental deduction, the nature and status of transcendental Ideas, the Antinomies), as well as those doctrines that are too often overlooked (e.g. the discussions in the 'Doctrine of Method' concerning definitions or those concerning the differences between opinion, belief, and knowledge). By thoughtfully engaging with the full scope of Kant's views, *New Anti-Kant* also introduces the reader to Bolzano's own positions in both theoretical and practical philosophy, as well as his philosophy of religion. Moreover, it does so in a way that, for readers more familiar with Kant's views than with Bolzano's (which will perhaps be most of its readers), promises to make Bolzano's positions more accessible insofar as they are introduced by reference to Kant's better-known terminology.

§2 A long and vigorous intellectual engagement

Bolzano's relationship to Kant is complicated and, perhaps for this reason, it is also often misunderstood. Part of the difficulty resides in the fact that the context in which Bolzano's theories evolved – and

in particular the circumstances that ultimately contributed to isolate Austrian Academia from the rest of the German-speaking world – is little known. At the turn of the nineteenth century, Kant's theories constituted the mainstream in Germany, and a vast portion of German intellectual life was recognizably “post-Kantian”, with lively debate for and against him, in a non-trivial sense. In Austria, by contrast, the rampant antagonism to which Kant's theories became subject in the 1790s, the subsequent imposition of bans on his books and the interdiction against including the study of his work in philosophy curricula in the years that followed, all made for a considerable lack of continuity with the kind of philosophy that was being done in neighbouring countries.¹ By the time Bolzano was admitted at Charles University in the late 1790s, Austrian philosophy students were being trained according to a rigid, state-imposed programme designed predominantly to promote Leibniz–Wolffian doctrines (with the help of official textbooks!). Given such a context, the vast interest Bolzano took in Kant's philosophy early on and the diligence with which he studied his theories are thus even more remarkable. Less surprising is the fact that this should have caused Bolzano to be singled out as a trouble-maker: a few months after he took up the chair of “Science of the (Catholic) Religion” in Prague in 1805, Bolzano was accused of being a “Kantian”, a label that would cause the professional demise of a number of his colleagues under the reign of Francis II. He could remain in his position only after he had ‘officially’ vindicated himself. Even this, however, was short-lived, as in 1819 Bolzano was eventually discharged for ‘heresy’.

Judged from the perspective of Bolzano's early publications, but especially in light of his own mature positions, one could wonder whether such charges of ‘Kantianism’ made much sense. But Bolzano's intellectual engagement with Kant's thought began quite early – in fact, years earlier than his appointment in 1805 – and proved to be deeply influential on the course of Bolzano's intellectual career in ways that ran much deeper than academic politics. In his *Autobiography*, we learn that Bolzano began to study the *Critique of Pure Reason* in 1799, when he was 18 years old.² From the outset Bolzano found himself in fundamental accord with Kant over the importance of the distinction between analytic and synthetic judgements, between *a priori* and *a posteriori* judgements, as well as between intuitions and concepts, among other things (*ibid.*).

¹ For a more complete picture, see Lapointe (2011, 11–17).

² *Lebenbeschreibung des Dr Bernard Bolzanos...* BBGA 1 10, 67–68.

Yet already by the time of his seminal *Contributions to a Better-Founded Exposition of Mathematics* (1810), Bolzano had also arrived at some of the basic commitments that would motivate his later criticisms of Kant's works. Indeed, the 'Appendix' to this work directly targets 'the Kantian theory of construction of concepts through intuitions' on the grounds (among others) that Kant's underlying doctrine of pure intuition is incoherent.³ Such criticisms were expanded extensively in Bolzano's writings throughout the 1820s and 1830s, his *Science of Religion* (1834), and especially in his *Theory of Science* (1837), with Bolzano now challenging Kant not just on his philosophy of mathematics but on all fronts (logic, epistemology, metaphysics, morals, religion, etc.). All of this ultimately coalesced in Bolzano's discussions with Přihonský in the late 1830s and 1840s, which eventually were to yield *New Anti-Kant*.

§3 The text

When he died in 1848, Bolzano left behind a considerable stock of unpublished writings, the bulk of which has now appeared in the *Bernard Bolzano Gesamtausgabe* (BBGA). František Přihonský was one of three of Bolzano's former pupils and/or collaborators to which the management of the latter was assigned.⁴ His contribution to Bolzano studies, though humble, was nonetheless the most significant among them. Perhaps most notably, we owe to him the publication of the *Paradoxes of the Infinite* (1851), a work that had considerable influence on the philosophy of mathematics and the emergence of set theory at the turn of the century, and which was both republished and then translated (into English⁵ and French⁶).

We also owe to Přihonský the publication of the thoughts captured in *New Anti-Kant*. Unlike the *Paradoxes*, however, this work is not to be counted as part of the *Nachlass*. Neither is it a disciple's tribute to the memory of his teacher. Rather, *New Anti-Kant* is the outcome of a collaboration between Bolzano and Přihonský that lasted over a decade.

³ See Laz (1993, 171–182) for a French translation of this Appendix, and Rusnock (2000, 198–204) for an English one.

⁴ The other two were Josef Fesl and Robert Zimmermann. The latter would be Franz Brentano's colleague in Vienna, which may partly explain the interest almost all of Brentano's most prominent students took in Bolzano, including Twardowski, Husserl Höfler, and Meinong.

⁵ By D.A. Steele (Ithaca, Yale University Press, 1950).

⁶ By H. Sinaceur (Paris, Seuil, 1999).

The project took form in early 1837 at Bolzano's initiative. Bolzano had heard of a French literary competition inviting submissions presenting critically the Kantian philosophical system and its idealist offshoots. The two philosophers who collaborated by correspondence were unable to meet the initial deadline, and even though the competition was protracted until the following year – for lack of high-quality submissions – Bolzano resolved not to take part in it. There were apparently two reasons for this decision: on the one hand, Bolzano was not particularly interested in spending time presenting the basics of Kant's ideas – what was supposed to be the first part of the essay. On the other hand, the idea of having to publish in French or in Latin (the official languages of the competition) was likely to prevent him from reaching the German-speaking philosophical public he was targeting.⁷

The project of a criticism of Kant and the idealists was not, however, abandoned. Bolzano and Přihonský divided the labour between themselves: Přihonský, with Bolzano's help, would deal with Kant; he ultimately delivered *New Anti-Kant*. For his part, Bolzano wrote three essays on idealism that were published posthumously by Přihonský,⁸ one year after *New Anti-Kant*. Bolzano also provided constant input into Přihonský's work, even offering to draft parts of the book. The manuscript, which was finished in 1847, was granted Bolzano's approval, though Bolzano succumbed to his lifetime struggle with pulmonary illness the following year, and so was unable to see the document through to publication.

§4 The reception of *New Anti-Kant*

New Anti-Kant's literary fate turned out not to meet what had been Bolzano's hopes and expectations: to contain "as much as he could – through the diffusion of distinct notions – the terrible disaster Kant unwittingly brought about in Germany through his philosophy".⁹ The initial distribution of the book was limited and its success dismal. Though we can find occasional references to the work – perhaps most notably by Hans Vaihinger in his *Commentary* on the first *Critique*, and by Benno Kerry, one of Brentano's students¹⁰ – few copies survived.

⁷ Morscher (2003) gives a more detailed account.

⁸ See Bolzano (1977).

⁹ In Bolzano's will. See Laz (1993, 7).

¹⁰ See Vaihinger (1922); we owe knowledge of Kerry's reference to Künne (1997, 32).

There is a record of a projected new edition of *New Anti-Kant* in the 1930s by Walter Dubislav and Heinrich Scholz,¹¹ though this unfortunately never materialized. Rather, all the way up through the 1990s, the work continued to languish in neglect. Evidence of this is that the only monograph (Laz 1993; in French) devoted to Bolzano's criticism of Kant actually never consulted *New Anti-Kant*: the author presumed that it was lost.

In recent years, the situation has much improved. A key factor here is Edgar Morscher's excellent new critical edition (in the *Beyträge zur Bolzano-Forschung*, vol. 7), with its meticulous revision of the passages quoted from Kant's works and its detailed introduction, all of which forms a tremendous resource for continuing research. Its appearance has dovetailed with *New Anti-Kant* beginning to garner more of the attention that it deserves within the circles of Bolzano studies. Yet even if its reception-history has begun to take a happy turn for the better, the depths of this work have by no means been plumbed, with existing discussion remaining neither exhaustive nor definitive.¹² Our translation of this little book is meant to bring it even further into the spotlight. What is more, we hope to make it accessible to an even broader readership: to English-readers primarily interested in Bolzano's own thought; those who are interested in his influence on the history of analytical philosophy at large and that of phenomenology; those who are already invested in Kant's thought and his context; and those who are looking for a fresh perspective to bring to bear on Kant scholarship and the history of German thought more broadly.

This work will add a new voice to the recent growth of interest in tracing out the Kantian themes in the history of theoretical philosophy in the analytic tradition (epistemology, philosophy of logic, mathematics, and science).¹³ Readers will find in *New Anti-Kant* a repository of ideas to which they can compare their own assessment of the fate of Kant's doctrines. And though some will be struck primarily by the confirmation of their own opinions or those of other canonical figures *avant la lettre*, there are many original insights and theories contained in it that deserve to be studied on their own merit. This is perhaps unsurprising

¹¹ See Morscher (2003, 191–201).

¹² E.g. Laz (1993); Rusnock (2011, 2013). See also the recent publication of a special issue of *Grazer Philosophische Studien* devoted to Bolzano and Kant (Lapointe 2012).

¹³ See Hanna (2001). See also Rockmore (2006).

insofar as there has been increasing interest of late in the extent to which Bolzano's own views might actually be preferable to those of his more well-known successors (e.g. Frege and Tarski) on several core issues in analytic philosophy.¹⁴

New Anti-Kant also contains much that will be of interest beyond the audience of analytical philosophers. Most directly, the work has a clear significance for anyone already engaging in Kant studies, and especially for anyone interested in how Kant's programme was received by those working outside of the now-canonical German idealist tradition. There were of course other *Anti-Kants* in the years following the first *Critique* – e.g. that of Stattler (1788) and then eventually Bollinger (1882) – but nothing that can be compared to Přihonský's economical and yet systematic examination of Kant's philosophy through the lens of Bolzano's systematic philosophical programme. Indeed, what distinguishes Bolzano from almost all of Kant's other official 'commentators' is the fact that his views are rooted in a fully worked out and highly accessible theoretical alternative, and one that on both fronts had few peers for most of the century that followed.

Finally, Bolzano's unique position in the history of philosophy – engaging both Kantians and analytical philosophers – has much to teach us as we continue to rethink the relative boundaries of what count as two distinct philosophical traditions. For, as has been recently well documented, in addition to his many anticipations of analytical philosophers Bolzano also stands as one of the major influences on the founder of the phenomenological movement, Edmund Husserl.¹⁵ What is more, Bolzano actually emerges as a point of reference for several of the correspondents Husserl and Frege had in common.¹⁶ The present work can therefore provide another occasion to better understand the extent to which the sources of ostensibly diverging contemporary traditions ultimately have considerable overlap (not least by both tracing back to Kant).¹⁷

¹⁴ On the comparison with Frege, see Künne (1997); on the comparison with Tarski, see Siebel (2002) and Rusnock and Burke (2010).

¹⁵ See Husserl (1900).

¹⁶ See Künne (2009). See also Lapointe (2011, 139–157).

¹⁷ Rethinking Husserl's relation to Bolzano in light of *New Anti-Kant* represents an especially salient opportunity here for furthering of the dialogue between the history of analytic philosophy and that of phenomenology, insofar as Husserl's own thought, too, became increasingly oriented around his engagement with Kant and the neo-Kantians.

Perhaps above all, though, *New Anti-Kant* can serve as the occasion to acquaint oneself with the thoughts of a brilliant philosopher whose tragic literary fate is nothing less than a historical injustice. For, as it contains many pages of philosophically perceptive and insightful discussions of topics of both historical and contemporary significance, the work promises to connect up with any number of debates, in several different kinds of traditions, that have grown up in the aftermath of Kant's philosophical interventions. For all of these reasons, the editors of the present translation share the conviction of Dubislav, Scholz, and Morscher – and, ultimately, that of Přihonský himself: that Bolzano's criticism of Kant has much to teach, even today.

§5 Complementing the text

In addition to the text of *New Anti-Kant* itself, the present volume also includes four essays, each of which investigates a different aspect of Bolzano's critical engagement with Kant, and which thereby serves to link up the discussions in Přihonský's text with the broader context of ongoing debate over the nature and significance of Bolzano's and Kant's positions themselves. To be sure, they are by no means exhaustive treatments of their topics. Instead they are intended to help better foreground what is at stake – both philosophically, but also interpretively – on a number of the fundamental issues that bring the two authors into dialogue, in an order that follows out the structure of the work itself: the nature of our sensible representations (Tolley), the nature of logic as the science of our intellectual (conceptual) representations (Stang), the proper conception of practical reason and the fundamental moral law (Rosenkoetter), and the very nature of Bolzano's putative “anti-Kantianism” (Lapointe and Armstrong).

These treatments centre around the three ideas that immediately come to mind when one sets out to situate Bolzano among Kant's numerous early commentators and to highlight what makes his criticisms unique and his own programme distinctive: Bolzano's sustained engagement with mathematics, his conviction in the necessity of a radical logical reform, and his commitment to a utilitarian conception of morality. Much of what Kant has to say in the *Critique* bears on mathematics: the distinction between analytic and synthetic judgements, between *a priori* and *a posteriori* cognition, the fundamental difference in method between philosophy and mathematics due to the necessity of constructing mathematical concepts in pure intuition, his views on axioms and definitions, and so on. The fact that Bolzano was himself

deeply invested in mathematics and made foundational contributions to it gives him an internal perspective on all of these issues, and so one that is highly valuable, since Bolzano had the obvious advantage of having (unlike Kant) an intimate, first-hand knowledge of advanced mathematical practice. Trained in the discipline, Bolzano spent the first decades of his career working on mathematical proofs and writing on foundational questions, before turning more directly to philosophy. It is unsurprising, therefore, that Kant's remarks on the philosophical foundations of mathematics and his contrast between mathematical and philosophical method would have functioned as a continuous point of departure for Bolzano's engagement with Kant's views. Indeed, his continued interest and circumspect examination of Kant's philosophy should be understood as continuous with his seminal contribution to mathematics and its philosophy.

What do we find in this examination? What's noteworthy when comparing their views is as much their consensus as their disagreement. Take, for instance, the nature of mathematical knowledge. On the one hand, Bolzano agreed with Kant that mathematical knowledge is not analytic. On the other hand, Bolzano radically rejected Kant's appeal to pure intuition, in both arithmetic and geometry. In this respect, Bolzano's project in the philosophy of mathematics can be understood as an attempt to provide an alternative account of synthetic *a priori* cognition. In his contribution, Tolley explores what consequences the rejection of pure intuition has for Bolzano's views about space and spatial representation, and, in particular, what role (if any) such representations have to play in our intuitions of outer objects. Since Bolzano rejects the notion of pure intuition, he also rejects the idea that our most original representation of space takes the form of such a pure intuition. Bolzano's reasons for this departure also require Bolzano to give up on the idea that space can function as the general form of outer intuitions – and indeed, as Tolley argues, must give up on the idea that spatial representation can be involved in outer intuitions *at all*. Even so, Bolzano nevertheless joins Kant in accepting that space, and with it the subject-matter of geometry is an ideal (non-actual) object. What is more, Tolley shows that Bolzano also accepts that spatial representation does not represent any actual properties of outer objects, but only has a representation-internal role to play. According to Tolley, Bolzano's arguments for these conclusions draw on what Bolzano himself takes to be deeper commitments actually shared by Kant, all of which serves to point up a tension in Kant's doctrine of intuition which is still being explored today in the debates over Kant's alleged conceptualism.

Bolzano's departure from Kant on mathematical knowledge is also one firmly anchored in the conviction that the key to understanding logical and conceptual relations is the rejection of certain core features of the (Leibnizian, Kantian) conceptions of analysis and truth that were paradigmatic at the time. In their essay, Lapointe and Armstrong seek to situate Bolzano's contribution to logic and mathematics within the rationalist tradition – between Leibniz and Kant – and document the fact that in spite of his many reservations in points of detail, Bolzano's programme remains eminently post-Kantian. That a reform of logic is central to Bolzano's entire project, and by extension to his criticism of Kant's theories can hardly be overplayed. It serves as a very fruitful starting point for a reconstruction of the debate between the two philosophers. For Bolzano disagreed with Kant on a number of fundamental logical issues and endeavoured to produce new theories that would better suit the purpose of logicians. These include accounts of the nature of truth and representation, the analytic/synthetic distinction, the definition of what counts as a valid inference, and the proper definition of modal notions (necessity, possibility, and contingency).¹⁸ Yet even while Bolzano is surely critical of Kant, he also repeatedly affirms the conviction that Kant's philosophy has effectively much of interest and value to say about these topics. Indeed, contrary to a commonly held belief about Bolzano's sympathies, Lapointe and Armstrong demonstrate that Bolzano develops his own revisionary views on logic in the *Wissenschaftslehre* by engaging more directly and sustainedly with Kant and the Kantian logicians, than with Leibniz or his successors.

Despite his productive engagement with Kant and the Kantians, Bolzano did find himself in fundamental opposition to Kant on the issue of whether logic itself can undergo any further scientific progress. Bolzano not only believed (against Kant) that such progress was possible, but also viewed such progress in logic as a necessary pre-condition for lasting scientific progress in philosophy as a whole. While Kant's *Lectures on Logic* show, for instance, that Kant was interested in logic and its theory, he also famously declared that logic was "closed" and "finished" (1781, Bviii). Nonetheless, Kant devoted much effort to the philosophy of logic, especially to the proper characterization of its subject-matter. As Stang's essay documents at length, Kant's views on what is distinctive of logic, its *formality*, aroused much interest, not least in Bolzano himself. Yet though Bolzano agrees with Kant that there is a sense in which logic

¹⁸ These notions are all expediently presented by Přihonský in his remarkably concise and informative Introduction, to which we refer the reader.

is ‘formal’, Bolzano also is deeply critical of Kant’s conception of what the relevant ‘forms’ are, and is critical in particular of Kant’s distinction between the form and matter of a judgement. While acknowledging that Bolzano’s own conception of the forms at issue in logic is a rich and fruitful one, Stang argues, first, that Kant can (and does) actually accept the core insight behind Bolzano’s own characterization of logic as ‘formal’ (in its focus on substitutability). Stang argues, furthermore, that it nevertheless fails to capture something important that Kant was picking up on in *his* use of ‘form’, concerning what ultimately unifies the subject-matter of logic. Stang contends that Kant takes logic’s principles to be formal in the deeper sense that their validity is grounded in the end or purpose set for our understanding as a capacity for thinking and cognizing – namely, that our understanding is oriented towards the truth.

The broader question of the ends, goals, and purposes of existence is the main focus of Rosenkoetter’s essay, which explores the foundations of Bolzano’s moral philosophy from the point of view put forward in Kant’s *Groundwork*. As Rosenkoetter shows, Bolzano not only had a fully worked out broadly consequentialist theory of what it would mean to abide by this principle, he also uses this alternative to formulate serious and probing criticisms of Kant’s deontological approach. Yet while Rosenkoetter also highlights the extent to which Bolzano’s preferred version of consequentialism is one which is tailor-made, so to speak, to avoid Kant’s most frequent criticisms of doctrines that ground morality in a duty to happiness alone (because Bolzano emphasizes the general – even impersonal – happiness at large, rather than any one person’s individual happiness), Rosenkoetter concludes that Bolzano’s position is ultimately unstable, and should either be developed in a direction towards the hybrid form of consequentialism later put forward by Moore, or should actually embrace something closer to Kant’s position. Rosenkoetter’s focus helps to remind us that, while Bolzano’s views on logic and mathematics certainly take centre stage in many of his works, Bolzano’s reasons for choosing to devote his life to teaching “Religious Sciences”, as opposed to mathematics, were in great part rooted in what he took to be his moral obligation to bring about the greatest sum total of happiness in the world.

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